

Data Work, and Deterministic Code Over Model Arithmetic

THE IDEA IN ONE LINE

Ask the model to write the thing that counts, then read what it wrote.

WHY IT WORKS

The model produces text by prediction. When it "computes" in prose, it is predicting what the answer looks like. When it writes a script and runs it, the script does the computing. The script is deterministic: same input, same output, every time, and you can read it.

THE PATTERN

1. Write code that does X. (Not "do X.")
2. Run it and show me the output.
3. Explain each line in plain English.
4. Spot-check one value against the source.

USEFUL PHRASINGS

- Before computing, print the column names and the first five rows so I can confirm you loaded it correctly.
- Add a sanity check: the counts should sum to the total row count.
- If any value is missing or malformed, stop and tell me rather than dropping it silently.

WHERE THE TRICK APPLIES

Counting, filtering, joining, aggregating, plotting, reshaping, date math, string cleanup, anything Excel can do and then some.

WHERE IT DOESN'T

Deciding what to count. Framing the question. Judging whether a result matters. Writing the paragraph that explains it. That's still your job, and the model is a critic there, not a calculator.

PITFALLS

- Trusting a chart you didn't inspect the code for. Axis choices lie.
- Letting the model "handle" missing data. Ask what it did.
- Skipping the read-the-code step because it worked. It worked *this time*.

GO DEEPER

- The code execution or data analysis documentation for the RAND-approved tool.
- Simon Willison on using LLMs for code, including for non-programmers: simonwillison.net
- Ethan Mollick, *One Useful Thing*, on the "jagged frontier" of what models do well: oneusefulthing.org